



Back to BlackBerry

Miss your BlackBerry OS? Here's how you can transform your Android to look into one.
<http://dgit.in/AndToBB>

Not so creepy, Apple

Following differential privacy, Apple will not collect any data secretly for its AI training, unless you allow it.
<http://dgit.in/iDiffPrv>

Feature

Another startup that is making quite a lot of noise in the Indian home automation scene is Inoho. Although it doesn't have a range of options, it does what it does well. It specialises in remote switches that can be controlled via an app. It was founded two years ago and has gone on to become one of the highest funded startups in this segment. Inoho's products are also available on Amazon at ₹11,999 for a starter kit that includes a controller and a 5.1 switchboard and ₹5,499 for 5.1 or 4.1 switchboard panels.

Apart from startups, some established brands are also offering home automation solutions and you might just decide to go for reliability over other factors. Oakter offers kits at flexible price segments that include Smart plugs, thermostats and switchboards and range from ₹2,800 to ₹10,000 while letting you build your own kits. Anchor by Panasonic offers a premium range of products with its Ave Domina fully scalable home automation system as well as standalone products. Anchor's products are not being sold online and are available at a store near you as of now.

Global Standards

Almost every global software giant is now gradually getting involved in home automation, along with a number of manufacturers who have already made a global reputation in this field. Belkin, with its WeMo line of products, can be considered as a global equivalent of Inoho, with good reputation in whatever few products it is producing. Nest, currently



Belkin's WeMo line is quite popular globally as home automation devices

Given the popularity of iOS devices, HomeKit shows huge promise

owned by Google, makes some really well designed products. These guys designed the iPod after all. The Nest learning thermostat, which, as its name says, learns your cooling and heating preferences over a week of usage. Its other two products, the Nest smoke and Carbon Monoxide detector and the Nest smart camera are equally intuitive. The smart camera actually incorporates a feature called Nest Aware that you have to sign up for, which allows the camera to use advanced algorithms to separate false alarms from tree branches and harmless objects from actual intrusions and risks. It also does the same for sounds.

Considering the number of good brands out there with a number of good end products, it is not feasible to list all of them here. Rather, what's impossible to ignore is the rise of voice as the future of home automation. The idea of a perfectly automated home is one where you don't have to figure anything out and the home does everything for you. Voice is a natural interface for that level of automation, as it removes the need for buttons and allows you to operate your devices with natural language commands. Amazon's Echo with the virtual assistant Alexa can interact with hundreds of devices and services, and according to latest developments, it will soon be able to grasp your emotions and respond accordingly. No wonder Amazon is having trouble keeping these in stock. This is exactly



HomeKit

why Google has also announced Google Home, their own version of the Echo.

Although Apple hasn't launched or announced a similar hub, what is has announced and released is Homekit. It's a framework for home automation that lets you make your devices talk to each other and lets you control your smart devices using Siri. This will be possible even when you are away from home (if you have a 3rd generation or higher Apple TV and they are connected to the same network). Apple has also included a Home app on iOS 10 for streamlined setup and control of your home from any iPhone, iPad or iPod touch running iOS 8.1 or later, or an Apple watch with watchOS 2. According to Apple, over 50 manufacturers are making accessories for Homekit.

The Future Home

We already have a lot of devices available that definitely seemed like science fiction even 10 years ago. With the growing proficiency of the voice interface, the perfect smart home that we described in the beginning soon might not be as imaginary as you think right now. It will surely feel more natural to just speak your plans out loud and have your devices work on them for you. For instance, making dinner plans? Simply speak out, "I'm making Pasta tonight for three friends with whom I'll watch football" and watch your home spring into action to make life easier for you.